

your computer could be infected by a worm. They'll have many malicious effects such as causing a server to crash, render a user's files unusable or create a backdoor to track a computer.

Rootkits

A Rootkit is often a collection of programs which are hidden deep into your system. They enable administrator-level access to a computer or computer network. An attacker installs a rootkit on a computer after first obtaining user-level access, either by exploiting a known vulnerability or cracking a password, and then hides its presence on a PC. The first rootkit was documented in 1990s on Sun and Linux operating systems but today rootkits are available for a number of operating systems, including Windows, and are increasingly difficult to detect on any network.

Once the rootkit is installed, it allows the attacker to mask intrusion and gain root or privileged access to the computer and, possibly, other machines on the network. It creates a backdoor and allows the hacker to send spam email or use the target PC to perform a denial-of-service (DoS) attack on servers. Detecting it is tough as it will conceal its presence in a computer. One means to detect it is by running a virus scanner when it's not running because a rootkit masks itself as a useful utility and the anti-virus can't detect it. If a rootkit is detected, however, the only sure way to get rid of it is to completely erase the computer's hard drive and reinstall the operating system. This is because anti-virus and malware removal tools running on an untrusted system may be ineffective against well-written rootkits.

Zombies

A zombie computer, or "drone," is a computer that has been secretly compromised by hacking tools which allow a third-party to control the computer and its resources remotely. When a trojan has infected a user's laptop, it can open a "backdoor" to permit hackers to use the infected computer for malicious purpose without the owner's knowledge. The user generally remains unaware that his computer has been taken over – he



Worms – a pain in the behind since time immemorial